

After your wisdom teeth

RECOVERY GUIDE · THIRD MOLAR REMOVAL

Keep this guide handy
Call our office with any questions

Wisdom teeth are more involved than most extractions — they sit deep in the jaw, usually require bone removal, and sometimes sit right next to a nerve. Your recovery will take a bit longer than a routine extraction, and the first few days can feel rough. That's normal. Here's what to expect and what to do.

TODAY	DAYS 2–4	DAYS 5–7	WEEK 2+
Rest. Gauze. Ice. Soft, cool foods. Don't disturb the sites.	Peak of pain, swelling, and jaw stiffness. This is the worst stretch.	Noticeable improvement. Jaw loosens. Diet expands.	Mostly back to normal. Full tissue healing takes several weeks.

WHAT THE PAIN & SWELLING CURVE USUALLY LOOKS LIKE



1 The first 24 hours

PROTECT THE BLOOD CLOT

A blood clot forms in each socket — it's your body's bandage. Losing it early is the main cause of "dry socket," which wisdom teeth are especially prone to.

- ✗ No rinsing, swishing, or spitting for 24 hours — let saliva gently drain
- ✗ No straws, no vaping, no sucking motions for 72 hours
- ✗ No smoking for at least 72 hours (longer is better)
- ✗ Don't poke the sites with your tongue or finger

BLEEDING

Bite firmly on gauze for 30–45 minutes. Oozing and pink saliva for the first day is normal.

💡 **If bleeding restarts:** fold a fresh gauze (or a damp black tea bag — the tannins help) over the socket, bite firmly without checking for 30 minutes, and keep your head elevated.

ICE FOR SWELLING

- 20 minutes on, 20 minutes off, for the first 24 hours
- You'll have "chipmunk cheeks" — this peaks at 48–72 hours, not the day of surgery
- After 48 hours, switch to warm moist compresses
- Bruising on the cheeks or neck is normal and can appear days later

EAT SOFT, COOL FOODS

GOOD CHOICES

- ✓ Yogurt, cottage cheese, pudding
- ✓ Smoothies (spoon only — no straw)

AVOID FOR AT LEAST A WEEK

- ✗ Hot temperatures (can restart bleeding)
- ✗ Hard, crunchy, chewy foods

- ✓ Mashed potatoes, applesauce
- ✓ Scrambled eggs, soft pasta
- ✓ Lukewarm soup, broth

- ✗ Chips, nuts, popcorn, rice, seeds
- ✗ Carbonated and alcoholic drinks
- ✗ Straws and spoons pressed into the sites

REST

Take 3–5 days off from work or school — ask us if you need a written excuse. No exercise, heavy lifting, or strenuous activity for at least 72 hours — elevated blood pressure can restart bleeding. Sleep with your head elevated on an extra pillow the first few nights.

Days 2 through 7 and beyond

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2 Pain, swelling, and a stiff jaw

Days 2, 3, and 4 are the peak. After that, each day should be a little better than the last. A combination of **ibuprofen + acetaminophen** is as effective as prescription opioids for most dental pain — see your **Medication Guide** for dosing.

A STIFF JAW IS EXPECTED

Most patients can't open their mouth very wide for about a week. This is called **trismus** — the muscles around the surgical area tighten up from the surgery and swelling. It usually peaks on day 2–3 and slowly improves over 1–2 weeks. Gentle jaw-opening stretches after day 3 (without forcing it) can help.

3 What's normal vs. what's not

NORMAL (EXPECTED)

- ✓ Peak pain and swelling at days 2–4, then daily improvement
- ✓ Bruising of cheek, jaw, or neck (can appear days later)
- ✓ Jaw stiffness limiting how wide you can open
- ✓ Yellow or whitish tissue in the sockets (healing, not pus)
- ✓ Slight bad taste or smell for a few days
- ✓ Slightly altered or "less sharp" sensation in lip, chin, or tongue that's gradually improving
- ✓ Food packing into the sockets (especially lower sites)

CALL OUR OFFICE

- ✗ Severe pain on day 3–5 that medication doesn't touch at all (possible dry socket)
- ✗ Pain, swelling, or bad taste that returns *after* you'd started to feel better (possible infection)
- ✗ Bleeding that won't stop after 30–45 min of firm pressure
- ✗ Fever over 101°F
- ✗ Numbness or tingling in lip, chin, or tongue that isn't clearly improving by the next morning — call right away if an area still feels completely frozen once the anesthetic should have worn off
- ✗ Jaw stiffness getting worse (not better) after day 5

 **Is it dry socket?** If your pain medication brings pain down to a manageable level (around **2 or 3 out of 10**), it's *not* dry socket — you're on a normal healing curve. If the medication does **nothing at all**, that's the hallmark of dry socket. Call us; it's easily treated with a medicated dressing that brings fast relief.

 **Is it an infection?** Watch the *direction* of your pain, not just how much it hurts. After day 4, each day should be a little better. If you were improving and then the pain, swelling, or a bad taste suddenly comes back, that's the classic pattern for an infection. Call us.

 **Why do these happen?** Dry socket and infection are the most common complications after wisdom teeth — combined, they happen in roughly **15–30% of cases**, higher than simple extractions because wisdom teeth sit deeper and are harder to access. The mouth isn't sterile the way skin is; even with sterile instruments and careful technique, some patients still develop one. Both are usually straightforward to treat — call us and we'll take care of it.

 **About nerve sensation:** The nerves that give feeling to your lip, chin, and tongue sit close to the lower wisdom teeth. It's common for these areas to feel a little "off" or less sharp for a day or two — usually from nerve bruising, which almost always fully recovers on its own. What we want to know about — the same day or next morning, not later — is **complete numbness** (feeling like you're still frozen from dental anesthetic) that persists after the local anesthetic should have worn off, or altered sensation that isn't clearly improving day to day.

4 Rinsing & hygiene (start tomorrow)

- Mix ½ tsp salt in 8 oz warm water. Rinse gently 3–4× daily, especially after meals.
- Let water *fall out* of your mouth — don't spit forcefully.
- If you have a plastic **curved-tip syringe** (we may give you one), start using it around day 5 to flush food out of the lower sockets. Aim low and away from the clot.
- Brush the rest of your teeth normally starting tomorrow. Avoid the surgical sites directly for 3 days.
- If you have a **chlorhexidine (Peridex) rinse**, continue it twice daily as you did before surgery; use saltwater the rest of the day.

5 Other things that may help

- **Bromelain** (500 mg, 3× daily, 5–7 days) — a pineapple-derived enzyme with research support for reducing swelling and speeding recovery after oral surgery. Skip if you take a blood thinner, have a bleeding disorder, or are allergic to pineapple.
- **Sleep** — 7+ hours a night. Sleep loss measurably slows healing.
- **Protein** — aim for 80–100g daily. Soft options: Greek yogurt, cottage cheese, eggs, protein smoothies (spoon only).
- **No nicotine or cannabis smoke** — smoking, vaping, or nicotine pouches significantly increase the risk of dry socket and delay healing. Avoid completely for at least 72 hours; a week or more is better.
- **No alcohol for at least 72 hours** — interacts with medications and slows healing.

When to call us

- Severe pain on day 3–5 that your medication doesn't help at all (possible dry socket)
- Pain, swelling, or bad taste that returns after you'd started to feel better (possible infection)
- Heavy bleeding that won't stop after 30–45 min of firm gauze pressure
- Swelling spreading to your neck or around your eye
- Fever over 101°F
- Numbness in lip, chin, or tongue that isn't clearly improving by the next morning
- Jaw stiffness getting worse (not better) after day 5

URGENT — DON'T WAIT

- Difficulty breathing or swallowing
- Rapidly spreading swelling to your neck, under your tongue, or around your eye

Call our office right away for the on-call provider. If you truly cannot breathe or swallow, call 911.

Wisdom teeth recovery can feel worse than expected around days 2–4 — you're not alone, and it doesn't mean anything is wrong. If something doesn't feel right, call us.